the Ukraine–Russia conflict, my views were that there would be many lessons to be learnt that would really emerge once the war was over and histories written. What was immediately clear though was that wars can still happen and they are not relics of the past. We ourselves had come to the brink of war, and therefore there was a need for robust capability development. Power, especially military power, flows from the barrel of the gun. China, of course, would remain our first and foremost concern, their rapaciousness knowing no bounds. In July 2020, at the height of the Ladakh crisis, they even raised a fresh claim on the Sakteng Wildlife Sanctuary deep inside Bhutanese territory.[1]

We had been able to achieve much on the HR front, particularly in the grant of PC to women officers. I had also opened up combat aviation to women officers, two of whom were undergoing training. I had hoped that they would have qualified during my tenure, in which case I would have personally gone to present them their 'Wings', but that was not to be, due to Covid-induced delays.[2] I also pointed out that during my tenure, there was representation at the Army Commander level, not only of the Infantry and Armoured Corps but also of the Mechanized Infantry, Engineers, Artillery and Air Defence, which just went to prove that there was no 'lanyard' culture and that merit and merit alone was the deciding factor. We had walked the talk and restored the confidence of the rank and file of the organization.

One can't choose one's comrades—superiors, subordinates or peers. But what one can do is learn from them all, the good and the bad. The good to emulate and the bad to discard. The good list is endless—Madan Das (first Commanding Officer), Kanwar, Ashok Kapur, Harjeet, Muthu . . . Pargat Singh (first Subedar Major), Dilbagh Singh (Communist), Faqir . . . I

Copyright © Penguin Random House India Not for circulation